

A Winter *on the Costa del Sol*

Your 2026 Guide

**A complete handbook for those considering 1 to 9
months in Southern Spain**



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A note from Bluevera



Why this guide exists

Each year, thousands of people from Northern Europe and North America — most of them in their late fifties or beyond — choose to spend part of their winter on the Costa del Sol. Most of them don't move permanently. They come for two months, four months, sometimes six — to escape the cold, to walk on the beach in February, to give their lungs a break from heating bills that have doubled in five years.

What they discover, almost without exception, is that the hardest part of the experience is not the sun, the food or the people. It is everything that comes before arrival: which town to choose, how the new Andalusian rental rules affect them, whether their NHS or EHIC cover travels with them, what a "seasonal contract" actually means in Spanish law, and — for British and non-EU citizens — how to legally stay longer than 90 days.

This guide was written to answer those questions. It is not a brochure. It does not try to convince you that wintering in Spain is a good idea — if you are reading this, you have probably made up your mind already. What we have tried to do is condense, in one place, the practical information that takes most people six months of scattered research to find.

If after reading it you would like to talk to someone, you'll find a quiet invitation at the end. No pressure, no sales calls. Just a guide.

— The Bluevera team



01 — The Costa del Sol in winter

What to expect between November and March

The southern coast of Spain has one of the mildest winter climates in continental Europe. Average daytime temperatures between November and March hover at 16-19 °C, with around 320 sunny days a year and rainfall concentrated in short bursts rather than long grey weeks.

But the real winter character of the coast is not in the numbers — it is in what those numbers allow. People walk to the bakery in shirtsleeves at midday in January. The almond trees flower in February. Outdoor markets, cafés and beach paseos operate year-round. For someone arriving from a country where winter means three months of darkness and a heating bill that has doubled in five years, the psychological effect is immediate.

A few things worth knowing before you book.

Mornings and evenings are colder than the daytime suggests. The Mediterranean sun is generous between eleven and five, but temperatures drop quickly after sunset, sometimes to 8-10 °C in January.

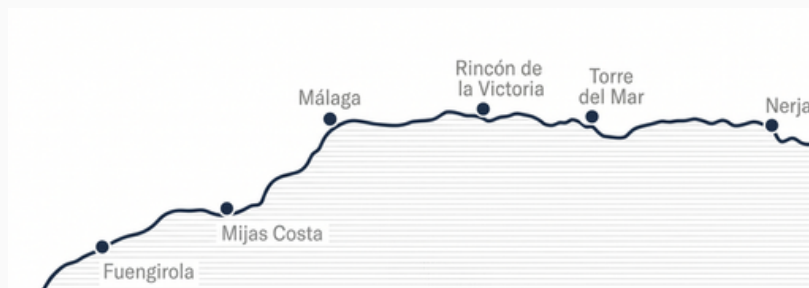
Most coastal apartments were built for summer ventilation, not winter retention. We come back to this in Section 04.

The "winter season" is not the same everywhere on the coast. Fuengirola and Mijas Costa stay busy year-round. Nerja and the Axarquía slow down considerably between November and February — quieter, more authentic, substantially cheaper, but with fewer English-language services.

December and early January are festive but functionally limited. Spanish public holidays cluster heavily in this period — 6, 8, 25 December, 1 and 6 January — and most offices close around them. If you are planning bureaucratic appointments (NIE, empadronamiento, S1 registration), avoid these weeks. February and March are far more practical.

Rain, when it comes, comes briefly. The Costa del Sol averages 50-60 days of rain per year, mostly in November and March. Long grey weeks — the kind that define winter further north — are genuinely rare.

Month	Daytime High (°C)	Nighttime Low (°C)	Rainy Days
November	19°C	11°C	6
December	16°C	8°C	7
January	16°C	7°C	6
February	17°C	8°C	5
March	19°C	9°C	5



02 — Choosing your corner

From Fuengirola to Nerja

The 85 kilometres between Fuengirola and Nerja are not a single place. They are a sequence of distinct micro-locations, each with its own rhythm, demographic and price level. Choosing the right one matters more than choosing the right apartment within it. Here is how local long-stay residents actually distinguish them.

Each of these places attracts a different demographic. The British and Irish concentrate westward, around Fuengirola and Mijas. Scandinavians have made Los Boliches their second home for fifty years. Germans and Dutch lean east, toward Nerja and the Axarquía villages. The Spanish are everywhere, but particularly visible in Málaga capital and the towns east of it. Knowing this is not about choosing your nationality — it is about understanding that the social fabric of each place is genuinely different, and what feels welcoming to one person can feel alienating to another.

Fuengirola & Los Boliches — the international hub. Density of services unlike anywhere else on the coast. Direct commuter train to Málaga airport (28 minutes). Strong British, Irish and Finnish communities with their own associations, bookshops, churches and cafés. The Bridge clubs of Los Boliches are among the most active in Spain.

Best for: first-time winterers, anyone who values walking distance to everything, those who don't want to drive. Trade-off: the busiest stretch of the coast, with summer-season noise extending into October.

Mijas Costa & La Cala — quieter coastline, easy access. A 10-kilometre stretch of urbanisations and small towns between Fuengirola and Marbella. Calmer than Fuengirola, with hillside properties offering proper sea views. Walkable centres in La Cala de Mijas and Calahonda.

Best for: couples who want quiet but not isolated. Walkers, golfers, light social life. Trade-off: a car becomes useful, sometimes necessary.

Málaga capital — culture and density.

Spain's sixth largest city, transformed in the last fifteen years into one of the country's cultural capitals. Picasso, Pompidou, Carmen Thyssen and a dozen smaller museums. Direct AVE high-speed train to Madrid (2h20). The historic centre is largely pedestrianised.

Best for: those who want urban life — concerts, exhibitions, restaurants — within walking distance, and don't need a beach view. Trade-off: central Málaga has the strictest short-term rental restrictions on the coast. Seasonal contracts are still available but the inventory is tighter.

Rincón de la Victoria & Torre del Mar — Spanish-feeling coast.

The first towns east of Málaga. Less internationalised, predominantly Spanish-speaking, but with growing communities of German and Dutch winterers attracted by the lower prices and slower pace.

Best for: those who want immersion rather than expat comfort, and who speak — or are willing to attempt — some Spanish. Trade-off: fewer English-language services, less established community for newcomers.

Torrox & Nerja — the eastern garden

Often described as having "the best climate in Europe" — a meaningful claim, given that Torrox averages 18 °C in winter and is sheltered from the western winds that occasionally affect Fuengirola. Hillside villas, dramatic cliffs, a slower rhythm. Nerja's old town retains genuine character.

Best for: longer stays (4+ months), nature, those who prioritise climate and tranquillity over urban services. Trade-off: a car is essential. Specialist healthcare requires a 50-minute drive to Málaga.

No location on this 85-kilometre coast is objectively better than another. They are different places that suit different people. The single most useful thing you can do, before signing a four-month rental anywhere, is to visit during the actual season you intend to come — November or February, not summer. A coastal town in July tells you nothing about how it feels in February. Even a long weekend, ideally split between two contrasting zones, is more revealing than weeks of online research. Most first-time winterers underestimate how different Fuengirola feels from Nerja, or central Málaga from a hillside in Mijas — and the difference is hard to read from photographs. A scouting visit works best when it is structured around what you actually need to test: whether the streets feel alive at 8pm in February, whether you can walk to a doctor or pharmacy, whether the apartment block has heating that actually works. These are rarely the questions a short visit ends up checking on its own — they need to be asked deliberately, and ideally with someone on the ground who has asked them many times before.



03 — How long can you stay?

The legal framework, by nationality

Your right to stay in Spain depends entirely on your nationality. The rules changed significantly after Brexit and continue to evolve — here is the current picture, valid as of 2026

EU citizens

Germany, Ireland, Netherlands, Scandinavia, France, Italy and other EU member states

You can enter Spain freely and stay indefinitely. For stays longer than 90 days, you are required to register with the Central Register of Foreigners — the Certificado de Registro de Ciudadano de la Unión, often called the "green certificate".

The procedure is straightforward but requires an appointment, proof of sufficient funds (or pension income) and proof of healthcare cover. Most local police stations process the registration within four to six weeks.

UK citizens — the 90/180 rule

Since 1 January 2021, British passport holders are subject to the Schengen rule: a maximum of 90 days within any rolling 180-day period, counted across the entire Schengen area combined.

Practical example. If you spend 60 days in Spain in October and November, then take a weekend trip to Paris in February, those Paris days count against your remaining Spanish allowance.

Exceeding the limit — even by accident — results in fines of €500 to €10,000 and, in some cases, a Schengen entry ban. The rule is enforced.

The European Commission provides a free official calculator at <https://ec.europa.eu/assets/home/visa-calculator/calculator.htm?lang=en>

British citizens who want to stay longer than 90 days, along with American, Canadian, Australian and Latin American visitors, fall under a different framework. We turn to it overleaf.



For citizens outside the European Union — including British, American, Canadian, Australian and Latin American visitors — the path to staying longer than 90 days runs through a single document: the Non-Lucrative Visa (NLV). The visa itself is the same for everyone, but the practical considerations differ by nationality.

US and Canadian citizens

Americans and Canadians can enter Spain visa-free for up to 90 days within any 180-day period, like UK citizens. For longer stays, the NLV is the standard route for retirees. A growing number of US citizens are choosing Spain over traditional retirement destinations like Florida or Mexico, drawn by healthcare quality, walkable cities and the relative strength of the dollar against the euro. Spanish consulates in New York, Miami, Los Angeles and San Francisco have seen NLV applications from American retirees rise sharply since 2020.

Australian and other non-EU nationals

Australia, New Zealand, Japan and a number of other countries also enjoy 90-day visa-free entry, then apply for the NLV for longer stays. The financial requirements and document checklist are identical to those for British and American applicants.

Latin American citizens

Citizens of most Latin American countries (Argentina, Mexico, Chile, Colombia, Brazil, Uruguay) can enter Spain visa-free for up to 90 days, then apply for the NLV through the same process.

A meaningful difference applies to Iberoamerican applicants. Under bilateral agreements, Argentinian, Chilean, Mexican and most other Latin American nationals can apply for Spanish citizenship after only **two years** of legal residence in Spain — instead of the standard ten — while retaining their original nationality. For families considering a longer-term move, this often makes Spain considerably more attractive than other European destinations.

The Non-Lucrative Visa: how it works

The NLV is a residence visa for non-EU citizens of independent financial means who do not intend to work in Spain. The 2026 financial requirement is approximately €2,400/month for the main applicant, plus €600/month for each dependant, demonstrated through pension statements, savings, rental income or a combination.

The application is made at the Spanish consulate in your country of residence, before travelling. It cannot be applied for from inside Spain. Processing typically takes two to four months. The visa is initially valid for one year and renewable for two-year periods thereafter.

Among the documents the consulate requires: proof of accommodation in Spain. Holiday-platform bookings (Airbnb, Booking.com) are routinely rejected. A formal seasonal rental contract under Spanish civil law (LAU) is the standard accepted format — and one of the most common reasons applications fail when this format is not provided.

04 — Seasonal rentals explained

The contract that makes everything else possible

The Spanish rental market has three legally distinct categories, and confusing them is one of the most common — and most expensive — mistakes foreigners make. Here is how each one works, and why only one of them fits a winter stay.

	Vivienda habitual	Arrendamiento de temporada	Vivienda turística
Purpose	Permanent residence	Defined seasonal stay	Short tourist stay
Typical duration	5+ years (renewable)	32 days to 11 months	1 to 31 days
Legal framework	LAU, art. 2	LAU, art. 3	Regional tourism law
Written contract	Required	Required	Often a booking confirmation
Accepted by consulate for NLV	Yes	Yes	No
Allows empadronamiento	Yes	Usually yes	No
Tenant protection	Highest	Strong	Minimal
Best for	Permanent move	Winter stays of 1-9 months	Holidays under one month

The category that fits a typical winter stay is the seasonal rental — contrato de arrendamiento de temporada. It is regulated by the Spanish Civil Code and the Urban Leases Act (LAU), and requires a written contract that explicitly states the temporary purpose of the stay: winter retreat, medical treatment, work assignment, sabbatical, or any other genuinely temporary motive.

This explicit purpose clause is not a formality. A contract that fails to state it can be reclassified by a judge as a permanent residential lease, with all the long-term tenant protections that implies — a legal grey zone that Spanish landlords avoid by drafting properly, and that foreign tenants benefit from understanding before signing.

The seasonal rental is more protective than a tourist booking. You hold legal rights as a tenant, your deposit is held under specific rules (fianza registered with the regional housing authority), and the landlord cannot evict you arbitrarily during the agreed period.

Beyond legal protection, the seasonal contract is the document that unlocks the rest of a winter stay. Three things in particular.

It is the format consulates accept for the NLV. Airbnb confirmations are not. As we noted in Section 03, this is one of the most common reasons Non-Lucrative Visa applications are rejected — applicants assume any accommodation proof will do, and learn otherwise after a four-month wait.

It usually allows you to register with the local town hall — the empadronamiento. This single registration is the gateway to public healthcare access, smooth bank account opening, and, for those who decide to stay longer, the residence visa renewal process.

It requires the property to genuinely meet the standards for temporary habitation. Real heating — not just air conditioning in heat mode. Functioning hot water. No humidity issues. Many coastal properties built between 1970 and 2000 were never designed for winter occupation, and this is the single most common complaint we hear from first-time winterers. We come back to this in Section 07.



05 — Healthcare

S1, EHIC and private cover

Few topics produce more anxiety among prospective winterers than healthcare — and few are more often misunderstood. Here is the practical map, by nationality and circumstance.

For EU citizens with EHIC

Your European Health Insurance Card covers necessary medical treatment during temporary stays in Spain. "Necessary" is interpreted reasonably — emergency care, GP visits, prescription continuity — but it is not designed to replace your home country's full coverage. For stays beyond a few weeks, register your card with a local Spanish GP (centro de salud) to access routine care.

For non-EU citizens or those preferring private

A Spanish private health insurance policy costs typically €60–€150/month for someone aged 65, with English-speaking doctors, no waiting lists and direct billing. The four major providers — Sanitas, Adeslas, Asisa and DKV — all offer policies designed for foreign residents. For NLV applicants, private coverage is the most common route to satisfy the visa's healthcare requirement.

The Costa del Sol corridor has international-standard private hospitals: Vithas Xanit (Benalmádena), Quirónsalud (Marbella, Málaga), HC International (Marbella) and Hospiten (Estepona). Most consultations are available in English, with specialist clinics for cardiology, orthopaedics and oncology — the three areas where older winterers most often need continuity of care.

For UK retirees

If you receive a UK State Pension, you are entitled to register an S1 form in Spain. The S1 transfers your healthcare coverage from the NHS to the Spanish public system, with the UK reimbursing Spain for your care. You retain the same rights as a Spanish national: full GP access, hospital care, prescription subsidies.

The S1 is requested from the NHS Overseas Healthcare Service (apply 3–4 months before travel) and registered upon arrival in Spain at the INSS office.

It is one of the most underused entitlements among British retirees in Spain. Many pay €60–€150/month for private insurance unnecessarily, simply because they didn't know it existed.

Contact: NHS Overseas Healthcare Service, +44 191 218 1999.

If you do not yet receive the UK State Pension, the S1 does not apply to you. Your default coverage is the GHIC (UK Global Health Insurance Card), which covers emergency care during temporary stays — but not routine treatment for stays beyond a few weeks. In that case, private cover (above) is the standard route.

06 — Costs

A winter on the coast

The table below covers a couple staying 3-6 months between November and April. We have separated three realistic standards — modest, comfortable, premium — so you can match the column closest to your situation rather than working from an average that fits no one.

CATEGORY	MODEST (€/month)	COMFORTABLE (€/month)	PREMIUM (€/month)	NOTES
Seasonal rental (1-bed)	€1.000	€1.350	€1.800	Fuengirola, Torre del Mar at the lower end; Nerja, central Málaga at the higher.
Seasonal rental (2-bed)	€1.350	€1.800	€2.500	Adds space for visiting family; same geographic logic.
Utilities	€140	€210	€300	Highly variable. Heating is the main driver between December and February.
Groceries (couple)	€400	€575	€800	Local markets and Spanish supermarkets cost 30-40% less than imported brands.
Eating out	€250	€475	€800	A <i>menú del día</i> costs €12-18; a Sunday lunch with wine €40-60 per couple.
Transport	€80	€150	€425	The corridor has good rail connections; many winterers manage without a car.
Health insurance	€150	€240	€350	Required for NLV applicants; optional for EU citizens with EHIC or UK pensioners with S1.
Leisure & culture	€75	€200	€425	Málaga's cultural offer is unusually rich for a city of its size.
Contingency	€100	€200	€350	We recommend including a buffer for unforeseen costs.
ESTIMATED MONTHLY TOTAL (1-bed couple)	€2.200	€3.400	€5.300	

A meaningful comparison: heating a UK semi-detached house through winter 2025/26 averaged £180-£250/month according to Ofgem; equivalent figures for a German Altbau apartment range from €200 to €320 (Verivox). Add council tax, standing charges and routine running costs of a closed-up house, and many British and German couples find that wintering on the Costa del Sol costs the same as — or less than — staying home.

07 — Avoiding the common pitfalls

Six things first-time winterers most often regret

None of the mistakes below are catastrophic, and all are avoidable. They are the regrets we hear most often from first-time winterers when they sit down with us in their second season.

Booking through holiday platforms for a 3+ month stay

Airbnb and Booking are designed for short tourism. Their cancellation policies, deposit handling and contract structure are not suited to seasonal stays — and crucially, they are not accepted as proof of accommodation for the NLV. Always insist on a written seasonal contract.

Underestimating heating

The single most frequent complaint we hear. Most coastal apartments were designed for summer ventilation, not winter retention. Before signing, ask explicitly: is there central heating, double-glazed windows, and what was the last electricity bill in January?

Bringing a pet without preparation

Spain accepts pets from the EU and the UK, but the paperwork is unforgiving: updated EU Pet Passport (or Animal Health Certificate for UK pets), microchip, valid rabies vaccination, and — for some destinations — a tapeworm treatment within a specific time window. Begin four months before travel. Once in Spain, register with a local vet within the first month, both for routine care and to keep your re-entry documentation valid.

Forgetting the 90-day clock

British, American and other non-EU retirees who travel within Schengen for weekend trips routinely forget that those days count against their Spanish allowance. Use the European Commission's official calculator (Section 03) and mark your dates before booking any side trip. Fines for accidentally exceeding the limit start at €500.

Choosing location without visiting in winter

A coastal town that feels alive in July can feel deserted in January, and vice versa. Some villages close half their restaurants from November to March; some apartment blocks empty out completely between October and April. Where possible, plan a short visit during the actual season you intend to come — even a long weekend, structured around two contrasting zones, will tell you what photographs cannot. The cost of that visit is trivial compared to the cost of choosing wrong.

Trying to do all the bureaucracy alone, in Spanish, in your first week

Spanish administration is not designed for newcomers. The NIE, empadronamiento and S1 registration each have their own queues, forms and quirks — and all are easier to navigate before you arrive than after. Whoever helps you find your apartment should also help with these registrations; if they don't, ask why. The cost of getting it wrong — failed appointments, missed empadronamiento windows, delayed NLV renewals — is invariably greater than the cost of getting it right.



08 — A week on the coast

How a winter week takes shape, from Monday to Sunday

No two winterers spend their week the same way. But certain rhythms are common enough among the people we host that we can describe them as a kind of template — neither fixed nor universal, but a useful starting point if you have never done this before.

Mornings

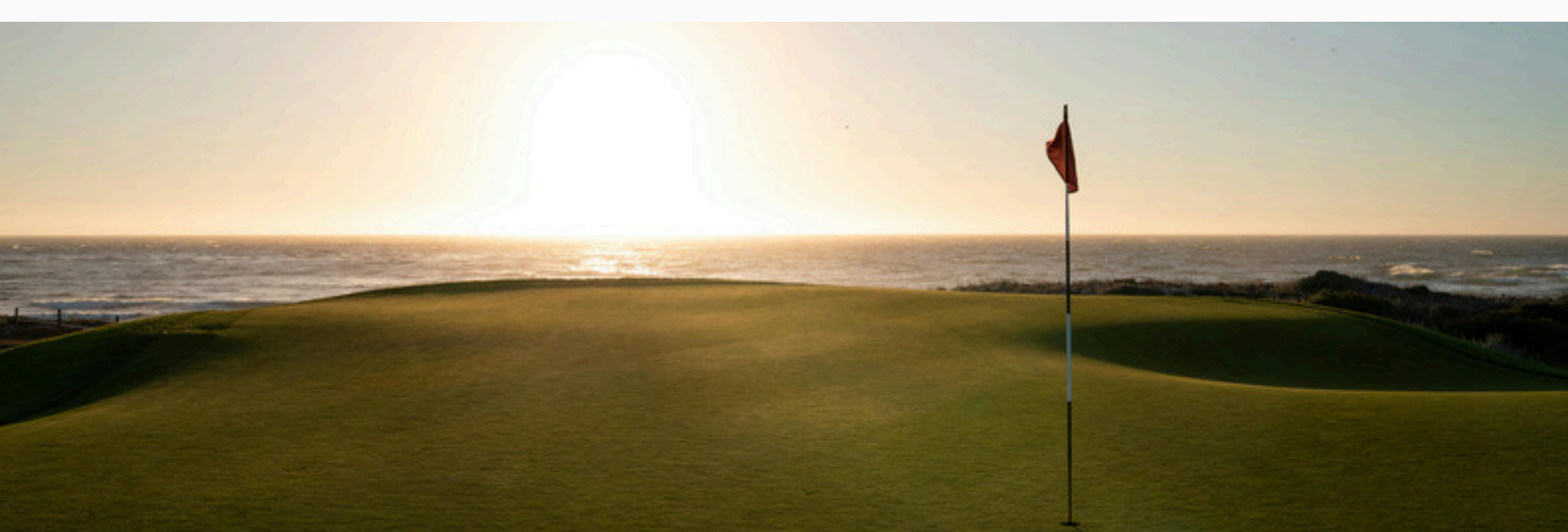
The coast wakes slowly in winter. Bakeries open at seven, cafés at nine. Mid-morning coffee is the social ritual that organises everything else — a bridge group that meets at ten thirty in one café, a language exchange at eleven in another, a Tuesday walking group that gathers at a particular train station because the path starts there and not somewhere else. People who come for two months and don't find their morning ritual rarely come back.

Markets and food

The Tuesday market in Fuengirola, the Wednesday market in La Cala, the Saturday market in Nerja. Each has its own personality, its own regulars, and its own unwritten rules. Learning which stallholder cuts the best jamón takes about four visits. Learning which fishmonger keeps wild sea bass aside for regulars takes about eight.

Afternoons and culture

Málaga's cultural offer is unusually dense for a city of its size — the Picasso Museum, the Pompidou, the Carmen Thyssen, the Russian Collection, twelve smaller museums and a year-round programme at the Cervantes Theatre. Concerts, lectures and exhibitions are heavily concentrated between November and March precisely because the resident population swells with winterers. The richest programmes circulate by word of mouth — a gallery's bilingual bulletin, the choir conductor's email list, a Tuesday coffee where someone always knows what is on next week.



Excursions within an hour

Ronda, Antequera, the white villages of the Sierra de las Nieves, the caves of Nerja, the Caminito del Rey, the Alpujarras above Granada. Almost all are one or two-hour drives, almost all are best in winter (cool, empty, dramatic light), and almost none are organised in groups designed for English-speaking residents — which is why most newcomers see one or two and miss the rest.

Golf and active life

For golfers, the practical questions tend to be specific: which courses accept walk-ins, which require federation handicaps, where the Tuesday and Thursday winter groups play, how to book green fees at short notice when the weather changes. Apps like Greenfee365 and Lola Golf cover the booking side; the rest is local knowledge. For walkers, several hiking groups along the corridor run year-round and welcome newcomers without registration — the trick is knowing which one matches your pace and which Saturday they meet. For cyclists, the coastal road from Fuengirola to Marbella is unusually safe in winter compared to the rest of the year.

The unexpected

Apartments break. Boilers fail in January precisely when you need them. The wifi router needs replacing. A neighbour's leaking pipe is suddenly your leaking ceiling. None of this is dramatic if there is someone on the coast who can be at the property within two hours, speaks both your language and the plumber's, and knows which technician will come out on a Saturday in February. Without that, a small fault becomes a long week.



09 — Beyond the apartment

Stays with purpose

One of the least discussed realities of long stays abroad is loneliness. Charity organisations working with British and northern European expats in Spain — Age Concern, the Royal British Legion, Lux Mundi — consistently report that social isolation, more than weather or paperwork, is what brings people back home earlier than planned. It is also why so many first-time winterers do not return for a second season. The remedy is not complicated, but it does not happen by accident.

The Costa del Sol has one of Europe's densest networks of expat associations, hobby clubs and volunteer organisations. Bridge clubs in Los Boliches with active leagues throughout winter. German hiking groups in Nerja that walk every Saturday. Scandinavian cultural associations in Mijas. Branches of the U3A — the University of the Third Age — in Fuengirola, Estepona and Málaga, running weekly talks in English on everything from Spanish history to astronomy. Anglican parish networks. And a particularly active charitable sector — including CUDECA, the British-founded hospice in Benalmádena — that runs largely on volunteer time, much of it given by retired expats themselves.

What we actually do here

Knowing these networks exist is one thing. Knowing which ones fit your background, language, mobility and interests — and where the active members actually meet on a Tuesday afternoon in February — is another. Part of what we do at Bluevera, beyond finding the right apartment, is point our guests toward the right communities. Informally, in conversation, based on what we know about each network and about each person who arrives.

For some, that means an introduction to a Bridge club two streets from their apartment. For others, it means a few hours a week behind the counter of a CUDECA charity shop, sorting donated books or serving coffee to other volunteers. For others still, it is joining a U3A walking group and discovering a corner of the Axarquía they would never have found alone.

What these very different choices have in common is structure. A reason to leave the apartment on a specific day, at a specific hour, to meet specific people. That structure — modest as it sounds — is what most often turns a good winter into one worth repeating. A good winter on the coast is not just a warm one. It is one with a rhythm and a purpose.



Balcón de Europa, Nerja

A note from Bluevera

You've reached the end of the guide. We hope it has answered more questions than it has raised.

Bluevera Residences is a small boutique agency for winter stays on the Costa del Sol — between Fuengirola and Nerja, no further west or east. We do three things, in this order of importance:

We verify each property in person before adding it to our portfolio — heating, internet, accessibility, contract, the things that look fine in photographs and matter in February. We handle the administrative side that newcomers usually find hardest — drafting seasonal contracts that meet consular standards, walking guests through NIE, S1 and empadronamiento during their first week. And then — the part most relocation services do not do — we stay. We are the call you make when the boiler fails on a Saturday. We are the introduction to the Tuesday walking group, the right golf foursome, the volunteer programme, the choir that takes new members in November.

We are not a concierge in the hotel sense. We are something closer to a well-connected neighbour who happens to also speak your language. We work with a deliberately small portfolio, and an equivalent number of guests each winter. Enough to know each apartment by heart and each guest by name. If anything in this guide raises a question that applies specifically to your situation, we offer a 20-minute call, free of charge, to talk it through. There is no follow-up sequence and no commitment of any kind. If we can help, we'll say so. If we can't, we'll point you toward who can.

You can start the conversation at blueveraresidences.com/design-your-stay, or write to us at hello@blueveraresidences.com. Whatever you decide, we hope your winter ahead is a good one.

— The Bluevera team
Costa del Sol, May 2026